circumstances. The governor (Swaraj Kaushal) gave sanction to her decision and only then did she leave the state for Delhi.

As already described, her exit from Goa had also been because of compulsions of threat to life. In that case, however, the life in question was that of her daughter. Because of the inordinate delay in sanctioning leave that had been approved by her senior, the IGP of Goa, she had rushed to Delhi to take into her own responsibility her daughter's medical treatment. For that she had been declared to be absconding from duty, a charge, had it stuck, would have put paid to her career.

In late 1994, during her tenure as IG (Prisons) another uncalled-for controversy, which was made to develop, was on the distribution of condoms to prisoners. A doctor visiting Tihar Jail (New Delhi), as a part of the Health Care Day, went off his designated work and, on his own, questioned a few adolescent prisoners on the subject of homosexuality. He managed to confuse the scene and, thereafter, the following day, gave an interview to the press that the prison had 90 per cent homosexuals. This news went all over the world to the extent that even the BBC lapped up the item. For days the matter dragged on. Now here was an issue with which Kiran least wanted to be involved! She realized that if she did not clarify the professional stand, the doctor would continue to have a field run, just what he wanted. So she decided to clarify matters – and she had to do so any number of times! Once that process started, it led to a 'controversy', including a petition to the court challenging the validity of the law against homosexuality in the Indian Penal Code. Kiran Bedi's professional stand was as follows:

(a) The problem of homosexuality persists but not as made out by the doctor who issued a statement without an academic study.
(b) His observation, as he himself admitted, was on the basis of speaking to a small group of young boys only – how could that be treated as 90 per cent 'affected'?
(c) Homosexuality as per Indian law is an offence and the prison cannot promote it by giving condoms.
(d) The problem of homosexuality in Tihar Jail should not be encouraged with free availability of condoms.
(e) The majority opinion was against the practice as per surveys done within the prison.
(f) The relations, particularly wives, protested against the suggestion of condom distribution as they did not want their husbands to become homosexuals due to the environment which may foster this habit.
(g) Adequate provision had been made for dealing with individual cases of homosexuality, and, therefore, the status quo did not require a change as of now.
(h) The excessive overcrowding acted as a deterrent as it gave no space for privacy in the prison.

But for quite sometime, Kiran continued to refute the suggestions made by a supposedly qualified doctor! And this has added to her bank of controversies! Some pressed this issue further and insisted that although she may consider homosexuality a vice, yet world opinion on this subject was changing and that she had merely been imposing her own cloistered views and they were not necessarily right. Should we not also consider, then, the denial of rights to heterosexuality in prisons? After all, the jail is a place where certain rights and privileges are withdrawn from the inmates. The objective behind the far-reaching correctional reforms that had taken place in Tihar was to ensure that energies were not idled away but directed towards constructive, creative and wholesome activities. It was this